

MODEL PROPOSAL: INCREASING LATINA/O INVOLVEMENT IN POLICY DEBATE THOROUGH SUMMER DEBATE WORKSHOPS

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Abstract: Participation in debate offers tremendous benefits to its participants. While efforts to improve diversity among participants in debate have been ongoing there remains a gap in the preparation of debaters from Latina/o communities. In this essay we provide insight into the experience of setting up a debate workshop at a Hispanic-Serving Institution. The essay discusses challenges in setting up a debate workshop series and the pedagogical strategies used to make the workshop successful.

Introduction

Debate plays a unique and powerful role in the education process of young adults. Students, both in high school and at the collegiate level benefit from competitive forensics. However, as research indicates the balance of participation in competitive debate remains dominated by white males (Fine, 2004; Allen, Trejo, Bartanen, Schroeder, and Ulrich, 2004). While diversity remains a goal for various debate organizations, often the lack of outreach and infrastructure development for greater diversity starting at the high school level sets into motion a domino effect resulting in fewer minority

participants in debate overall. This essay focuses on the efforts of a Hispanic-Serving Institution (HSI) in the Southwest United States to develop a targeted summer debate institute for high school students in a minority-majority community along the United States-Mexico border. Our hope is that this essay provides insight into the planning and execution of similar outreach efforts throughout the United States. The essay starts by first describing the socio-economic characteristics of the host community and the nature of HSI-initiated education efforts. Given our sense of the academic community committed to the idea of these types of summer enrichment programs and for brevity's sake we briefly touch on the value of debate to the educational experience, particularly for minority students. Finally we devote the remainder of the essay to describing the structure of the institute and the pedagogical strategies driving instruction.

Opportunities in Hispanic Serving Institutions for Debate Outreach

Urban debate leagues have served urban populations for the last twenty years. The function and efficacy of urban debate projects has been well documented (Baker, 1998, English, Llano, Mitchell, Morrison, Reif, & Woods (2007), Lee, 1998, Preston, 2006, Warner & Bruschke, 2001). Indeed, our own experience with the Detroit Urban Debate League from 1998-2001 provided a foundational experience for the El Paso project. We feel, however, that documenting this workshop builds upon these efforts in an important way. First, the El Paso project deals with the specific challenges of a border community and the integration of debate workshop into a HIS. Second, this piece is purely pedagogical in that our aim is to design a practical model for teaching debate. Third, the model we propose is unique in its ability to work with a very limited amount

of resources. This project was designed and implemented through the voluntary services of three college debate coaches, three donated classrooms, and limited financial support from El Paso school district. Finally, our proposal suggests that the benefits of urban debate can extend beyond 'urban debate leagues.' In fact, there is no "urban debate league" serving El Paso, but our experiences indicate dedicated individuals can make a difference even in the absence of this important infrastructure.

El Paso, Texas is a unique bi-national, bi-cultural community located at the intersection of three states and two nations. The city is a border community with a population of close to 750,000. Economic data on El Paso reveals several factors that suggest a community under financial pressure with limited mobility to enhance the existing economic situation. Over 29% of the population in El Paso is classified as poor according to government standards, and the median household income in El Paso is approximately \$30,968 whereas the national average is approximately \$46,242 (Gilot, 2007). In any community where economic pressures exist the impact on education is always a concern, particularly as students cope with financial pressures and deficits in the educational infrastructure. Existing metrics suggest that high school graduation rates have increased from 69% to 76.6% over a ten-year period (El Paso Regional Economic Development Corporation, 2008). El Paso represents a microcosm of other border communities, particularly in the state of Texas; economics have been stunted and maximum potential is still a distant goal. Furthermore, as national demographics trend toward an increasing Latina/o population, communities such as El Paso, Texas reflect what is also a likely trend, the rise of minority-majority communities.

Colleges and universities designated as HSIs are positioned to be uniquely valuable to high school students. Geographically, HSIs are in cities with large

Latina/o populations that match the guidelines set by the designation. HSIs, cognizant of their locations and connections, have generally committed resources for outreach, recruitment, and retention of students in their home communities. While these efforts are diverse and have met with various levels of success, we believe that there has been little in the way of debate-based programming as a form of HSI outreach. Some of the limited outreach is due to the scarcity of active debate programs in existing HSIs. Additionally, the resource base for a debate-centered outreach might be seen as cost prohibitive. We believe that Hispanic Serving Institution-based summer debate instruction is not only valuable and can be developed to scale, but also that programming can be valuable to recruitment efforts aimed at Latina/o populations. Colleges and universities designated as Hispanic-Serving Institutions represent unique space for the education of the United States' Latina/o population. While educational opportunities and the rate of attainment of opportunities for Latina/os in the United States have grown slowly, efforts like the development of Hispanic-Serving Institution status is a direct effort to address shortcomings and underachievement in the education of Latina/os. Garcia (2001) argues that Latina/os are benefiting from attention to previous underachievement as well as from the impact of demographic growth. Laden (2004) explains that the HSI designation is applied to colleges and universities that have 25% of Latina/o students and whose income is constricted. The HSI, first recognized in 1965, is a designation similar to the Historically Black Colleges and Universities and Tribal Colleges and Universities designations. The designation is an attempt to direct resources to and create alliances for the advancement of Latina/o education. While early HSIs were clustered in states that had traditionally seen large Latina/o populations such as Texas, California, Arizona

and Florida, HSI designation has been recognized in areas like the Pacific Northwest has the potential to spread into the southeastern region of the United States.

The University of Texas at El Paso was an early part of the HSI system. Its population of students, drawn mainly from the communities of El Paso, Texas and Ciudad Juárez, Chihuahua, has largely been Latina/o. With a student population of approximately 20,000 people the university provides a wide range of degree programs at the bachelor's and master's levels with a small but growing number of doctoral programs. The University of Texas at El Paso, like its peer institutions with the HSI designation, aims to provide a complete education to its students and to serve the communities where they are located. As of 2007 data, the university served almost 73% Latina/o students bringing the total number of those enrolled to approximately 15,000 students.

Debate as a Tool for Civil Empowerment and Education

The study and practice of argumentation, van Eemeren, Grootendorst, and Henkemaans (2002) suggest is a "verbal, social, and rational activity" advancing arguments as part of a process that involves communication and interaction (p. xii). Snider (2008) adds that argumentation and debate center on change and serve as a microcosm of the constant, larger set of processes "to better...lives...community...and our future" (p. xiii). Driscoll and Zompetti (2003) emphasize that debate is valuable, particularly when viewed over a long period of time, as the activity fuels the drive to consensus and an "understanding of what is right and best" (p. 9). Educators have long agreed with the core ideas discussed above and the role of debating in the high school and junior high school levels have been an important part of the education process for some time.

The pedagogical benefits of competitive academic debate are rich. As an activity, debate incorporates public speaking, persuasion, critical thinking, research, and advocacy skills. At the most basic level debate is an activity that allows students to learn the basics of public speaking and communication (Bartanen & Frank, 1991; Colbert & Biggers, 1985; Wood, 1972). As a tool for empowerment, the ability to speak in public as an advocate for yourself and others is essential. The ability to be a public advocate is enhanced by the training academic debate provides in the tactics of persuasion (Guiliano, 1989; McBath, 1984). In addition, and perhaps most importantly, competitive academic debate enhances critical thinking (Colbert 1987; Colbert & Biggers, 1985; Pearce, 1974; Rothenberg & Berman, 1980). These educational benefits are of particular importance for students who might be lacking in traditional educational opportunities. It is clear that debate enhances education and often results in benefiting the entire educational experience for students involved.

Clearly the benefits of debating are undeniable with students having exposure to developing research, oral presentation, and critical thinking skills. However what appears clear from existing research (Fine, 2004; Allen, Trejo, Bartanen, Schroeder, and Ulrich, 2004) is that the diversity of debate participants in high school and in college is fairly homogeneous and less dynamic than societal demographics. Recent efforts undertaken by several groups have started the process to extend debating to students in socioeconomically challenged communities. By providing an infrastructure to make coaching available as well as to create tournament opportunities these groups are engaged in a unique pedagogical process. Reports by popular news media (Chemerinsky, 2008; Houppert, 2007; Hoover, 2003; Ervin, 2001) continue to point to successes emerging from urban debating program across the country.

Chemerinsky (2008) explains that debaters in these urban programs benefit from the focus on critical thinking and advocacy skills, as well as learning life lessons from coaches and teachers that impact the students well into their professional careers. Working from these initial successes and from a modified model of existing summer debate workshops, we propose guidelines to increase the critical thinking and oral presentation skills of Latina/os students and their peers. Portales and Portales (2005) advocate pedagogical strategies for teaching Latina/o students that emphasize building these very skills:

The idea is to teach students both to interpret all things and symbols that are communicated in print and to make them aware that everything they read, think, say, and write can improve how they are seen and assessed for advancement in society. (151)

We concur with this assessment and believe that debate training is the unique intersection of the skill sets that and Portales advocate Latina/o children need to have.

A Model Proposal for HSI Based Debate Workshops

Developing a high school debate workshop at a HSI comes with challenges. In order to effectively define our model we will first identify existing challenges, outline a set of desired outcomes based on those challenges, and design specific pedagogical measures that meet those outcomes. Our intent is twofold: to document our own experience in this process and to suggest ideas so that others interested in accomplishing a similar workshop can build on our experiences.

The first obstacles relate to limited institutional resources. The amount of resources offered by an institution has implications for the workshop. It is important to negotiate funding for the workshop early in

the planning stage. Splitting contributions between the HSI, the school districts involved, and generous volunteers, minimizes the financial footprint for any one of the parties. It is best to solicit space for the workshop at the HSI because it exposes high school students to a college campus and is usually easier to navigate than a public high school campus. Additionally we believe that exposure to the campus allows debaters to experience the campus environment as students. We believe that this is an important way to foreground the college-going experience.

It is possible that many of the students served by such a workshop will have little to no debate experience; a second obstacle. This creates a group of students, potentially ranging from the sixth grade to the eleventh grade, all with very similar experience levels of debate. Depending upon the total enrollment and the number of instructors it may or may not be possible to divide the group according to age/grade-level constraints. A limited number of total students and even more limited number of instructors can make skill and/or age grouping unattainable. Instructors must be prepared to instruct groups of varying levels alongside students who are taking the course for a second or third time.

Third, students are limited in time and resources. Time restrictions demand the workshop operate as a day camp. The time physically spent on campus limits the amount of time students have to develop a full range of debate skills. More challenging is the lack of resources available to students attending the workshop. Money for expenses traditionally associated with debate camps, such as for photocopies, laptop computers, or library computer costs should not to be expected or presumed.

A fourth challenge is the potential lack of support for debate available to each student after leaving the workshop. While it is expected that a number of students will have the opportunity to travel locally to compete

beginning in the fall, a significant number will not compete again until the following spring. Even with regular travel it is unclear how much coaching is available to students during the school year. Considering a great number of teachers attend the workshop along with the students to gain basic skills, it is reasonable to assume many of these programs have coaches with limited debate experience.

A final challenge is intellectual isolationism; for most students it is unlikely that they will have contact with the larger debate community through competition, coaching or judging. The byproduct of this challenge is a lack of diversity in judging, a lack of exposure to new arguments, and a disadvantage for students when opportunities to travel outside of the community do arise. Most importantly, it limits exposure to judges from college programs and thusly limits opportunities for advancement to debate at the collegiate level.

Acknowledging these challenges, our model sets three outcomes as institutional goals. The first goal is to create an understanding of the value and importance of debate in students and coaches that will resonate with administrators and parents. The attrition rate of students who participate in the workshop but never compete in a tournament is likely to be high based on the challenges present to the typical student. It is vitally important then to instill a sense of commitment from the students that the activity is useful, enjoyable, and that they have a real opportunity for success. Our second desired outcome is to prepare students to compete with minimal resources at both the personal and institutional level. If the debaters leave the workshop with a sense of empowerment about participating in debate, we believe that they will help sustain the programs in their respective high schools. The last educational outcome we hope to create is a basic understanding of the grammar of debate. Students should have confidence that the

principles and practices that they learn can translate to any policy debate experience in the country. While many have cited problems with academic debate, especially at the collegiate level, we believe that equipping Latina/o students to enter collegiate programs requires they understand the language and structure of the activity. The outcome is not to create collegiate NDT or CEDA debaters, but to create a basic understanding of the rules and language that govern the debate world so that students feel empowered to enter this community if they so desire.

Our model focuses on debate skills and theory development over a focus on research. Ours is a distinct approach as most existing models for debate workshops emphasize researching evidence and evidence production skills for their students. In the only quantitative analysis done of teaching methods across high school debate camps, Shoen and Matlon (1974) found that 82% of students spent between one and seven hours per day researching the topic. Undoubtedly, much of the educational benefits of debate arise from research and evidence production process and the knowledge gained from the researched evidence itself. However, due to the limitations created by the previously discussed challenges, it is impossible to focus on evidence production without sacrificing other important areas of debate. We find it most beneficial to focus on mastery of technical debate skills and knowledge as opposed to devoting time to reading, processing, and creating evidence. In providing a strong background on the basics of debate, students will naturally evolve to a point where they pick up evidence production skills. As such, we emphasize a linear learning model in which students learn a) the general benefits of debate as a competitive activity; b) the basics of argumentation and debate; and followed by c) evidence production skills. In order to facilitate the training of skills and theory, instructors

provide completed research assignments and students are encouraged to utilize professionally produced evidence handbooks to read and construct arguments as a class and individually. The importance of research and evidence production can be emphasized by the use of these evidence briefs.

There are three areas of debate knowledge that provide the best opportunity to achieve the outcomes previously listed: fundamental theory, technical debating, and argumentative strategy. We believe that these processes are concurrent although in the teaching model we propose and have used, the basic foundation of debate knowledge has started with fundamental theory.

Fundamental theory begins with a discussion of the general question: why do we debate? This might appear overly holistic, but to students who may have never seen an actual debate before, this is instructive in establishing a context for them to view debate throughout the rest of the camp and hopefully their debate careers. It also opens the door for early theory discussion in terms of education, fair play, debate-ability and so forth. The second question for discussion is: how do you win a debate? This may be the most important discussion to have as it will guide the remaining lectures and help fuel discussions of strategy for practice debates.

Following these discussions we move to specific fundamental topics including: presumption, stock issues, disadvantages, topicality, counter-plans, and kritiks. Distribution of evidence files occur during each lecture to enable students to gain exposure to each type of argument and move the students toward practice speeches and debates. Due to the short duration of the camp, it is important to prepare students for debates as quickly as possible. While our treatment of these issues is not exhaustive, the goal is to prepare the students for practice speeches and debates.

Teaching the technical aspects of debating is the most challenging portion of the camp. It takes time and practice to perfect these skills and both are in short supply. Students learn about speaker roles and responsibilities, time limits, and flowing. Two areas that we focus on are flowing and pre-round preparations such as 'front line briefs' and 'extension evidence.' The faster we cover these areas the sooner we can get the students into debate rounds. Following this model we are able to begin practice debates after only two days of preparation.

Having the students debates allows the instructors to focus on argumentative strategy. Positive reinforcement is essential to build confidence in the students. It is not always possible or useful to have a tournament for the camp, but we do evaluate each debate and provide oral reasons for a decision. Giving an oral decision at the end of the debate reinforces topics discussed during the week and allows the students to see how all portions of the debate fit together. It is also important to discuss strategy both during and following the round. Strategy topics include reasons for decision, judge adaptation, and strategic decision-making. This prepares students to coach themselves during the debate season.

As an ancillary component of the camp we have run a concurrent teachers workshop. The teachers move throughout the day from participating alongside students to specialized lectures. Often the pedagogical process for the teachers can be incorporated into a credit agreement, so that the debate coaches-in-training might receive continuing education credit for their participation in the workshop and the lectures. This two-pronged approach allows inexperienced coaches to learn the basics of debate. It also allows them to learn specific topics such as how to direct a program and manage a budget. A particularly useful practice is to have teachers judge

practice rounds alongside camp instructors. Consultation with the instructor can help coaches learn the activity on the same model as the students but from the perspective of judge rather than that of debater. This is particularly useful as the prospect of judging debates is one of the most intimidating factors for an inexperienced coach/judge.

Conclusion

The seeds for this article were planted through our experiences working under the guidance of George Ziegelmuller. George not only introduced us to urban debate, he demonstrated a commitment to expanding debate to as many students as possible. For all of the awards and accolades collected by George over his long tenure at Wayne State University, we will always be awed by his uncanny ability to develop novice debaters into champions. It is in this spirit that we hope to expand the benefits of debate to as many locations as possible.

Participating in debate serves a number of important functions including educating students in the argumentation process, enriching advocacy skills, and empowering young minds to participate in an engaged, intellectual social setting. While the process of opening space for minorities in debate is ongoing there remains a great deal of work to be done to ensure pathways into the activity are open and accessible. Mitchell (1998), writing about outreach efforts undertaken by urban debate leagues, describes argumentation training as a collaborative empowerment process. As our efforts through the UTEP experience demonstrate we concur with Mitchell's assessment and believe that efforts to target Latina/o high school students can be coupled with recruitment and outreach strategies at HSIs. Our strategies suggested in this essay would work well with future developments in the UDL system as well. Given financial and time constraints for developing debaters in

areas where previous resources were not available, a smaller more engaged pedagogical approach is warranted. Additionally efforts made to engage potential debate coaches can also follow the day camp model; coaches and teachers can be folded into the instruction of the summer institute.

Our sense is that with concentrated efforts, such as debate workshops at Hispanic-Serving Institutions, it is possible to develop a targeted outreach that can make a difference for minority students, and in particularly Latina/o students. In providing a sense of our own experiences in this process we hope that those interested in supporting such efforts can maximize their experience with our ideas. We believe that the workshops conducted using this model have been modestly successful and that the students that have participated have learned about debate and have a sense of what is available to them in terms of opportunities through debate.

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